



ON THE WRITE LINE

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BASKING IN GLORY OF MANU'S OLYMPIC MEDAL AND LEANDER, VIJAY'S INDUCTION INTO TENNIS HALL OF FAME

Manu Bhaker's Olympic bronze and the induction of Vijay Amritraj and Leander Paes into the International Tennis Hall of Fame were **proud moments** for India and Indian sports.

Manu Bhaker winning India's first medal in the Paris Olympics was such a heartwarming moment. When the Indian tricolour goes up, the chest swells with pride. She didn't let the disappointment of the Tokyo Olympics get her down. Instead, she worked harder and was rewarded with a medal this time.

Speaking of the Tricolour, it is so disgusting to see some people deface it by putting their company or institution's name on it. They are Indians but not Indian passport holders, so perhaps they do not understand the importance of the flag. Their wholehearted support for the Indian team is most welcome and much appreciated. And hopefully, they will devise a flag of their own that will be easily recognisable and not deface the Indian tricolour.

It was disappointing to see that the ICC turned a blind eye to this during the last two World Cups and did not do anything about it. The TV production companies are now aware of the insensitivity of this and rarely, if ever, show the defaced flag. Also, because the name on the flag is that of a company, that amounts to ambush marketing. For the UK and USA flags, it is different as those countries and their

citizens may not be concerned about the defacing of their country's flags. But the Indian government is pretty clear that the flag cannot be tampered with at all. Hopefully, good sense will prevail, and next time around, these Indian team supporters will attend the game with their own designed flag, which I am sure will become popular and recognised all over the cricketing world.

Last week also saw two of India's greatest sportspersons, Vijay Amritraj and Leander Paes, inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame. That was another chest-swelling moment for India and Indian sports. Both have not only been fabulous tennis players but also great role models. They have been India's unofficial ambassadors wherever they played and have won millions of friends for the country. Both are wonderful speakers too, gracious and witty to boot, which makes listening to them such a pleasure. Well done, both of you, and may you continue to serve the game for a long time.

The Major League Cricket, where I had the pleasure of commentating, has a new winner, with the Washington Freedom franchise winning the trophy. For some reason, the crowds were not quite there this time around. Maybe it was viewer fatigue because of the ICC